

Malayalam, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/malayalam/lessons/

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Malayalam set
in Noto Sans Malayalam (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This is the Malayalam volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Malayalam letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read നമസ്കാരം *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Malayalam simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Malayalam is the youngest of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is the **closest sister of Tamil**, having split from it only about a thousand years ago. That double nature runs through this book: its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (“thanks” is നന്ദി *nandi*, twin of Tamil *nanri*; “no” is ഇല്ല *illa*, twin of Tamil *illai*), while a vast Sanskrit layer — the old *Manīpravālam* tradition mixed the two freely — gives it a Sanskrit formal greeting (നമസ്കാരം) and the largest alphabet of the family. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

Contents

Preface	iii
The Malayalam script (reference)	1
1 Greetings	3
1.1 നമസ്കാരം (<i>namaskāram</i>) — “greetings,” a making of a bow	3
1.2 നന്ദി (<i>nandi</i>) — “thank you,” and the Tamil kinship made visible	4
1.3 അതെ (<i>athe</i>) — “yes,” literally “that [is so]”	5
1.4 ഇല്ല (<i>illa</i>) — “no,” shared almost exactly with Tamil	6
1.5 ശരി (<i>śari</i>) — “okay,” the whole-family word once more . . .	7
1.6 Recap, and how Malayalam says goodbye	7
2 Introducing Yourself	9
2.1 പേര് (<i>pēru</i>) — “name,” the native Dravidian word	9
2.2 എന്റെ (<i>enre</i>) — “my”	10
2.3 ആണ് (<i>āṇṁ</i>) — “is,” where Malayalam breaks with its sisters	10
2.4 എന്റെ പേര് ...ആണ് (<i>enre pēru ...āṇṁ</i>) — “my name is...”	10
2.5 നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (<i>nī / niṇṇaḷ</i>) — “you,” familiar and respectful	11
2.6 എന്ത് (<i>entṭ</i>) — “what”	11
2.7 നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (<i>ninre pēru entāṇṁ</i>) — “what’s your name?”	12
2.8 സന്തോഷം (<i>santōṣam</i>) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you” .	12
2.9 The whole exchange	12
3 How Are You?	15
3.1 എങ്ങനെ (<i>eṇṇane</i>) — “how,” another of the e- questions . .	15
3.2 സുഖമാണോ? (<i>sukhamāṇō</i>) — “how are you?”	15
3.3 ഞാൻ (<i>ñāṇ</i>) — “I,” the Dravidian first person	16
3.4 സുഖം (<i>sukham</i>) — “well-being,” and how to answer	17

3.5	സാരമില്ല (<i>sāramilla</i>) — “it doesn’t matter”	17
3.6	The whole exchange	17
4	Farewells	19
4.1	പോകുക (<i>pōkuka</i>) — “to go,” and വരിക (to come)	19
4.2	പോയി വരാം (<i>pōyi varām</i>) — “I’ll go and come back”	19
4.3	നാളെ കാണാം (<i>nāḷe kāṇām</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	20
4.4	വീണ്ടും കാണാം (<i>vīṇṭum kāṇām</i>) — “we’ll meet again”	21
4.5	The farewells	21
5	The First Verbs	23
5.1	സംസാരിക്കുക (<i>saṁsārikkuka</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	23
5.2	ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam”	24
5.3	താമസിക്കുക (<i>tāmasikkuka</i>) — “to live, to stay”	24
5.4	ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (<i>jōli ceyyuka</i>) — “to work”	25
5.5	Sentences about yourself	25

The Malayalam script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ക = ka, മ = ma, ര = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** കാ = k $\bar{a}$, കി = ki, കീ = kī, കു = ku, കൂ = kū, കെ = ke, കേ = kē, കൊ = ko, കോ = kō. (The *e/o* signs are written *before* their consonant but read after.)
3. **The *chandrakkala* strips the built-in vowel, and bare consonants join as conjuncts.** സ + ക → സ്ക (ska), ന + ദ → ന്ദ (nda), ല + ല → ല്ല (lla). A circle anusvāram ണ adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

അ a · ആ ā · ഇ i · ഊ ī · ഉ u · ഊ ū · എ e · ഏ ē · ഐ ai ·
ഒ o · ഓ ō · ഔ au.

Worth flagging

- **The largest Dravidian alphabet.** Because Malayalam borrowed so heavily from Sanskrit, it keeps the full Sanskrit inventory — aspirates (ഖ kh, ധ dh...) and all three sibilants (ശ ś, ഷ ṣ, സ s) — alongside native Dravidian letters Tamil also has (the retroflex ള ḷ, ഴ ḻ, ഹ ṇ).
- **Rounded forms, many conjuncts.** Malayalam’s curved letters and rich stock of stacked/ligated conjuncts give it a distinctive dense look.

Malayalam in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Malayalam is the *closest sister of Tamil* — the two split from one language only about a thousand years ago — so its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (*nandi*, *illa*, *śari*, and the *pōyi varām* farewell). At the same time it absorbed a vast Sanskrit layer, which is why its formal greeting (*namaskāram*) and its full letter-set are Sanskritised. The lessons trace, word by word, what is inherited Dravidian and what is borrowed.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Malayalam greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Malayalam script and how Malayalam sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C01-*.md.*

1.1 നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Malayalam reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ന na, മ ma, ര ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: ക ka + long-ā → കാ kā. The *chandrakkala* strips a vowel so consonants **join as a conjunct**: സ + ക → സ്ക “ska.” The **anusvāram** ണ adds a final nasal “-m.” Read നമസ്കാരം → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Malayalam ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār*. Worth marking, because Malayalam is otherwise the **closest sister of Tamil** — the two split only about a thousand years ago — yet it absorbed an enormous Sanskrit layer (the old *Maṇipravāḷam* style mixed the two freely), so its formal greeting is Sanskrit even as its everyday core stays deeply Tamil-like.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Malayalam	നമസ്കാരം <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Even Tamil’s closest sister took the Sanskrit greeting; Tamil alone kept its own.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 നന്ദി (*nandi*) — “thank you,” and the Tamil kinship made visible

The letters in this word

ന is *na*; ി is “ndi” — a **conjunct** of ന (*na*) + ി (*da*) into “nd,” with the “i” sign. Read നന്ദി → *nandi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നന്ദി (*nandi*) is **native Dravidian**, from the same root *nal* / *nan* (“good”) as Tamil *nan̄ri*. Malayalam and Tamil split from one language about a thousand years ago, so their oldest words are near-twins — “thanks” is a perfect case: Malayalam *nandi*, Tamil *nan̄ri*. Meanwhile Kannada and Telugu use the Sanskrit *dhanyavāda*, so the map of “thanks” traces the family’s fault-line exactly.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Malayalam	നന്ദി <i>nandi</i>	native (root <i>nal</i>)
Tamil	<i>nan̄ri</i>	the <i>same</i> native root
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Tamil and Malayalam on the native side; Kannada and Telugu on the Sanskrit side.

1.3 അതെ (*athe*) — “yes,” literally “that [is so]”

The letters in this word

അ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). തെ is “the” — ത (*tha*, a soft *th*) with the “e” sign, which is written *in front* of its consonant but read after. Read അ•തെ → *athe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

അതെ (*athe*) is native Malayalam, grown from അത് (*athu*), “that.” To say “yes,” Malayalam essentially says “**that [is so]**,” affirming by pointing at the truth of what was said. Its partner is *alla*, “[it is] not that.”

Grammar Lens

Malayalam’s yes/no are demonstratives in disguise: *athe* (“that [is so]”) vs. *alla* (“not that”). Like its sisters, Malayalam also answers by **echoing the verb** (*vannu*, “[I] came,” for “did you come?”). You agree by confirming *that* is how things are.

1.4 ഇല്ല (*illa*) — “no,” shared almost exactly with Tamil

The letters in this word

ഇ is the independent vowel “i” (word-initial). ള് is “lla” — a conjunct of ല (la) + ല (la), a held “ll.” Read ഇല്ല → *illa*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇല്ല (*illa*) is built on the ancient Dravidian root *il*, “not-being” — so, exactly like Tamil *illai*, it means “[it] is not, [there] is not,” serving as the everyday “no.” Its positive twin is ഉണ്ട് (*untũ*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Dravidian negates by *being*. Where English inserts *not*, Malayalam — like Tamil and Kannada — swaps in the negative verb of existence: *pustakam untũ* (“there is a book”) → *pustakam illa* (“there is not a book”). Strongest across the Tamil–Malayalam pair: Tamil *illai*, Malayalam *illa*, Kannada *illa* (Telugu was the outlier, with *lēdu*).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Malayalam	ഇല്ല <i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il</i> -
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i>	native, a <i>different</i> root
Hindi	<i>nahīnī</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

1.5. ശരി (ŚARI) — “OKAY,” THE WHOLE-FAMILY WORD ONCE MORE?

1.5 ശരി (śari) — “okay,” the whole-family word once more

The letters in this word

ശ is “śa” (a *sh*-sound). Having borrowed so much Sanskrit, Malayalam keeps the full set of Sanskrit sibilants (ś, ṣ, s) as separate letters — more than Tamil, which uses one. ി is *ri*. Read ശരി → śari.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ശരി (śari) is the pan-Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Malayalam. The same family word as Tamil and Kannada *sari* and Telugu *sarē*; Malayalam just spells its opening sound with ശ (ś). Doubled, śari śari = “fine, fine.”

Grammar Lens

One word, four scripts. *sari* / *sarē* / *śari* is the clearest single proof of how close these four languages are: one word, one meaning, four different scripts. Catching a shared word change its clothes but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the whole family at once — the reason to learn the four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Malayalam says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
നമസ്കാരം	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
നന്ദി	<i>nandi</i>	thank you	native (= Tamil <i>nanri</i>)
അതെ	<i>athe</i>	yes	native (“that is so”)
ഇല്ല	<i>illa</i>	no / isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ശരി	<i>śari</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

How **Tamil-like** the native core is: four of the five everyday words are shared with Tamil — because Malayalam is Tamil’s closest sister — while only the formal greeting reached for Sanskrit.

Why it's said this way

Nearly the Tamil words exactly. Malayalam, too, will not say a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*), “having gone, I [will] come [back]” — set beside Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*: the same sentence, the same worldview, and in Malayalam and Tamil almost the same *words*.

That completes the four Dravidian first chapters. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *enre pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Malayalam’s *nī* / *ninnīl* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്. (*enre pēru Arun āṇṭ* — “My name is Arun.”)
നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entāṇṭ* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C02-*.md.*

2.1 പേര് (*pēru*) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

പ (*pa*) + േ (the *ē*-sign) → പേ (*pē*); ൾ (bare *r*, with the chandrakkala).
Read പേര് → *pēru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പേര് (*pēru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **pēr* — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Telugu *pēru*, a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (*p*→*h*). Being Tamil’s closest sister, Malayalam naturally keeps the native word, *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*).

2.2 എന്റെ (*enre*) — “my”

The letters in this word

എ (independent *e*) + the conjunct ഞ് (*nre*) → *enre*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) is the possessive of ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, the same pronoun stem behind Tamil *nān* / *en*. No Indo-European cousin.

2.3 ആണ് (*āṇṁ*) — “is,” where Malayalam breaks with its sisters

The letters in this word

ആ (independent long *ā*) + ണ് (bare retroflex *ṇ*) → *āṇṁ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ആണ് (*āṇṁ*, “is”) is Malayalam’s **copula** — a real word for “is,” grown from the verb ആക (*āka*, “to be, to become”). Here is the surprise: Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu all use the **zero copula** — no word for “is” at all — yet Malayalam, though it is Tamil’s *closest* sister, went its own way and grammaticalised a “to be” verb. So where Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Malayalam adds *āṇṁ*: *enre pēru Arun āṇṁ*.

2.4 എന്റെ പേര് ...ആണ് (*enre pēru ...āṇṁ*) — “my name is...”

എന്റെ (my) + പേര് (name) + name + ആണ് (is) = *enre pēru ...āṇṁ*.
Enre pēru Arun āṇṁ. = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

The verb comes last — as in Hindi (*hai*) and unlike Tamil’s verbless sentence. Malayalam is subject–object–*verb*, and the copula *āṇṁ* closes the sentence: “my name Arun *is*.” (In fast speech Malayalis sometimes

2.5. നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (NĪ / NINŅAL) — “YOU,” FAMILIAR AND RESPECTFUL¹¹

drop *āṇũ*, but the full, correct form keeps it.)

2.5 നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (*nī* / *ninṇaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

നീ (*nī*); നിങ്ങൾ (*ninṇaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — the same native root as Tamil *nī*, Kannada *nīnu*, Telugu *nuvvu*. നിങ്ങൾ (*ninṇaḷ*) is the respectful/plural “you” — *nī* + a plural ending, the exact cousin of Tamil *nīṅgaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, once more. *nī* (familiar) vs. *ninṇaḷ* (respectful, literally plural) — the family’s shared politeness-by-plural, and the same idea as French *vous*. For a first meeting, *ninṇaḷ*.

2.6 എന്ത് (*entũ*) — “what”

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + the conjunct ന്ത് (*ntũ*) → *entũ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്ത് (*entũ*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-/e-* — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *eṇṇa* and Telugu *ēmiṭi*, heading Malayalam’s question family: *entũ* (what), *ār* (who), *evite* (where), *entīṇaṇũ* (why).

2.7 നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entāṇṁ*) — “what’s your name?”

നിന്റെ (*ninre*, “your”) is the possessive of *nī* (“you”). And watch the last word: *entāṇṁ* is *entū* (what) + *āṇṁ* (is), fused — so നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? is literally “**your name what is?**” Unlike the Tamil question (which had *no* verb), Malayalam’s carries its copula *āṇṁ* right inside the question-word.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Enre pēru Arun āṇṁ*. The respectful “your” is *ninnāḷuṭe*: *ninnāḷuṭe pēru entāṇṁ?*

2.8 സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is നിങ്ങളെ കണ്ടതിൽ സന്തോഷം (*ninnāḷe kaṇḍatil santōṣam*) — “**joy at having seen you.**” The word സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*, “joy”) is **Sanskrit** — the same loan Kannada and Telugu use. So even Malayalam, the great keeper of native words (recall *nandi* for “thanks”), reaches for Sanskrit here: the loan words spread *selectively*, word by word, which is exactly what these lessons trace.

2.9 The whole exchange

Malayalam		English
എന്റെ പേര് മീരാ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Mira āṇṁ</i>	My name is Mira.
നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്?	<i>ninre pēru entāṇṁ</i>	What’s your name?
എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Arun āṇṁ</i>	My name is Arun.
സന്തോഷം.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian **pēr*, *not name*), *enre* (from *nān*, “I”), *entū* (Dravidian question-stem), *santōṣam* (Sanskrit). And the Malayalam standout: it *has* a copula *āṇṁ* (“is”), where its Dravidian sisters use

none. Next chapter: *sukhamāṇō?* (“are you well?”) — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and Malayalam, unlike its sisters, asks it with a real verb “to be”:

സുഖമാണോ? (*sukhamāṇō* — “Are you well? / How are you?”)
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി. (*sukhamāṇũ, nandi* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C03-.md.*

3.1 എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*) — “how,” another of the e- questions

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + ണ് (*ṇṇa*, a doubled velar nasal) + നെ (*ne*) → എങ്ങനെ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base *e-* from *entũ*. Malayalam gathers its questions here: *entũ* (what), *eṇṇane* (how), *ārũ* (who), *eviṭe* (where), *eppōḷ* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* — the most native layer of a language otherwise rich in Sanskrit.

3.2 സുഖമാണോ? (*sukhamāṇō*) — “how are you?”

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being”) + ആണ് (*āṇũ*, “is,” from Chapter 2) + the question-marker ഓ (*ō*) → സുഖമാണോ — “is [it] well?” Where English says “how are you?”, Malayalam more often asks “are you well?”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — *sukha* = *su-* (“good, well,” the Greek *eu-*) + *kha*. Onto it Malayalam adds its **native** copula *āṇṁ* and the question particle *-ō*: a Sanskrit noun, a Dravidian verb — Malayalam in miniature.

Grammar Lens

-ō makes a yes/no question. Add ഒ (*-ō*) to the end of a statement: *sukham āṇṁ* (“it is well”) → *sukham āṇō?* (“is it well?”). No word-order change, no helper — just the little *-ō*.

3.3 ഞാൻ (*ñān*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ഞ (*ñā*, a palatal nasal like “ny,” at the very start) + ാ (long *ā*) + ൺ (the word-final *n*, a *chillu*) → ഞാൻ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **ñān* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) from Chapter 2.

Grammar Lens

Malayalam does not drop “I.” Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu verbs carry the person in their ending, so they freely drop the pronoun. But Malayalam verbs *do not change for person at all* (Chapter 5) — so *ñān* must be said; the verb won’t tell you who acts.

3.4 സുഖം (*sukham*) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort, ease”) is a **Sanskrit** loan, the *su-* of Greek *eu-*. Where Tamil answers “how are you?” with native *nalam*, Malayalam — Tamil’s closest sister, but far deeper in Sanskrit — reaches for *sukham*. The reply, with the copula: സുഖമാണ് (*sukhamāṇṁ*), “[I am] well,” reusing the greeting’s own words without the question *-ō*.

3.5 സാരമില്ല (*sāramilla*) — “it doesn’t matter”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സാരമില്ല means “there’s no matter to it” — used for “never mind / no worries / you’re welcome.” A perfect emblem of Malayalam: സാരം (*sāram*, “substance, essence”) is **Sanskrit**, while ഇല്ല (*illa*, “is not”) is the **native** Dravidian negative from Chapter 1. Sanskrit noun, Dravidian verb, one word. That *illa* is shared across **Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada** (Telugu alone diverges, to *lēdu*).

Grammar Lens

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *paṇam illa* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of the copula *āṇṁ* (“is”) — *āṇṁ* affirms, *illa* denies.

3.6 The whole exchange

Malayalam	English
സുഖമാണോ?	Are you well? / How are you?
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി.	I’m well, thank you.
സാരമില്ല.	It doesn’t matter / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *eiṇiane* (the native *e-* questions), *ñāṇ* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *sukham* (Sanskrit “well,” the *su-* of Greek *eu-*), and the *āṇṁ* / *illa* pair — “is” and “is-not,” the *illa* shared with Tamil and Kannada.

Next chapter: the farewells — and Malayalam, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Malayalam, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

പോയി വരാം. (*pōyi varām* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C04-.md.*

4.1 പോകുക (*pōkuka*) — “to go,” and വരിക (to come)

The letters in this word

പോ (*pō*) + കുക (*kuka*, the *-uka* infinitive) → പോകുക. Its partner വരിക (*varika*, “to come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോകുക (*pōkuka*, “to go”) and വരിക (*varika*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs. The ending *-ക* (*-uka*) is how Malayalam names a verb in the dictionary — its “to ...” form (where Tamil uses a bare stem). You need both, because the Malayalam goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) — “I’ll go and come back”

പോയി (*pōyi*, “having gone”) + വരാം (*varām*, “I’ll come”) — literally “having gone, I’ll come [back],” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Malayali

never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is പോയി വരു (*pōyi varū*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṁ</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The -ആം ending, “I will / let me.” -*āṁ* on a verb stem is a soft, volitional future: *varāṁ* (“I’ll come”), *kāṇāṁ* (“let’s see,” next lesson), *ceyyāṁ* (“I’ll do it”).

4.3 നാളെ കാണാം (*nāḷe kāṇāṁ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

നാളെ (*nāḷe*): നാ (*nā*) + ളെ (*ḷe*, retroflex ഉ *ḷ*). കാണാം (*kāṇāṁ*) = *kāṇ* (“see”) + -*āṁ* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നാളെ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native, from *nāl* (“day”) — the same root as Tamil’s *nāḷai* and Kannada’s *nāḷe*. കാണുക (*kāṇuka*, “to see”) gives *kāṇāṁ* — so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].”

4.4. വീണ്ടും കാണാം (VĪṆṬUṢ KĀṆĀṢ) — “WE’LL MEET AGAIN”²¹

4.4 വീണ്ടും കാണാം (*vīṇṭuṣ kāṇāṣ*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വീണ്ടും കാണാം = വീണ്ടും (*vīṇṭuṣ*, “again”) + *kāṇāṣ* (“let’s see”). Both native Dravidian: *vīṇṭuṣ* (“again,” from *vīṇṭu*, “to return”) and *kāṇ* (“to see”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Malayalam — like Kannada — keeps its own native verb.

4.5 The farewells

Malayalam	English
പോയി വരാം.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
പോയി വരു.	Go and come back. (the reply)
നാളെ കാണാം.	See you tomorrow.
വീണ്ടും കാണാം.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *pōkuka/varika* (go/come), *nāḷe* (“tomorrow” ← *nāl* “day,” shared with Tamil & Kannada), *kāṇ* (“to see”), and the *-āṣ* “I will” ending. Next chapter: the first real verbs — *ñāṇ malayāḷaṣ saṃsārikkunnu* — and Malayalam’s one astonishing simplicity.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and the one astonishingly simple thing about Malayalam grammar:

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു. (*ñāṇ malayāḷaṁ saṁsārikkunnu* — “I speak Malayalam.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C05-.md.*

5.1 സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

സം (*saṁ*) + സാ (*sā*) + രി (*ri*) + ക്കുക (*kkuka*) → സംസാരിക്കുക.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*, “to speak, converse”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *saṁsāra*, “flowing together”), beside the native *parayuka* (“to say”) — another sign of Malayalam’s deep Sanskrit layer. To say “I speak,” add the present ending -ഉന്നു (*-unnu*) to the stem: *saṁsārikk-* + *-unnu* → സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (*saṁsārikkunnu*).

Grammar Lens

The verb never changes for person. In Tamil, Telugu, and Kannada the verb changes ending for *who* acts. *Malayalam does not.* It is the same for everyone:

ñāṇ saṁsārikkunnu (I speak) *nī saṁsārikkunnu* (you speak) *avaṇ*

sam̐sārikkunnu (he speaks)

One form, all persons — which is exactly why (Chapter 3) Malayalam can never drop the pronoun. Of all its Dravidian sisters, Malayalam went the furthest here.

5.2 ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam”

ഞാൻ (I) + മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*, the object) + സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (speak) — “I Malayalam speak,” the verb last. The name മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*) is native Dravidian: *mala* (“mountain”) + *āḷam* (“place, region”) — “**the mountain land**,” for the Western Ghats along its coast. The signature retroflex ള (*ḷ*) sits in the middle of the word.

Grammar Lens

Because *sam̐sārikkunnu* is the same for every person, the pronoun ഞാൻ (*ñān*) cannot be dropped — it is the only thing marking “I.”

5.3 താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*, “to live, reside, stay”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *tāmasa*, “dwelling”); Malayalam often prefers such Sanskrit-built verbs where Tamil uses a native word (*vāḷ*). “I live in Kochi” is ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു (*ñān kocchiyil tāmasikkunnu*) — the same *-unnu* present, the same for every person.

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. കൊച്ചിയിൽ (*kocchiyil*) = *Kochi* + *-il* (“in”), on the noun’s *end*. Malayalam uses **postpositions**: “Kochi-in I live,” verb last, pronoun kept.

5.4 ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെയ്യുക (*ceyyuka*, “to do, make”) is core native Dravidian — the *same root* as Tamil *sey*. Like Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, and Kannada’s *māḍu*, Malayalam builds compounds with it: ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*, “work-do” = “to work”). So “I work” is ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു (*ñān jōli ceyyunnu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + ചെയ്യുക = a new verb — the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, Kannada’s *māḍu*. Five languages, two from an unrelated family, one shared trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Malayalam	English
ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു.	I speak Malayalam.
ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു.	I live in Kochi.
ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു.	I work.

Three verbs, one endlessly simple engine: the *-unnu* present, the verb always last, the same for every person — so the pronoun always stays. Roots banked: *saṃsārikkuka* (Sanskrit; native twin *parayuka*), *tāmasikkuka* (Sanskrit; where Tamil uses native *vāl*), *ceyyuka* (the *same root* as Tamil *sey*), and *malayāḷam* = “the mountain land.” From here, Malayalam’s sentences only grow.